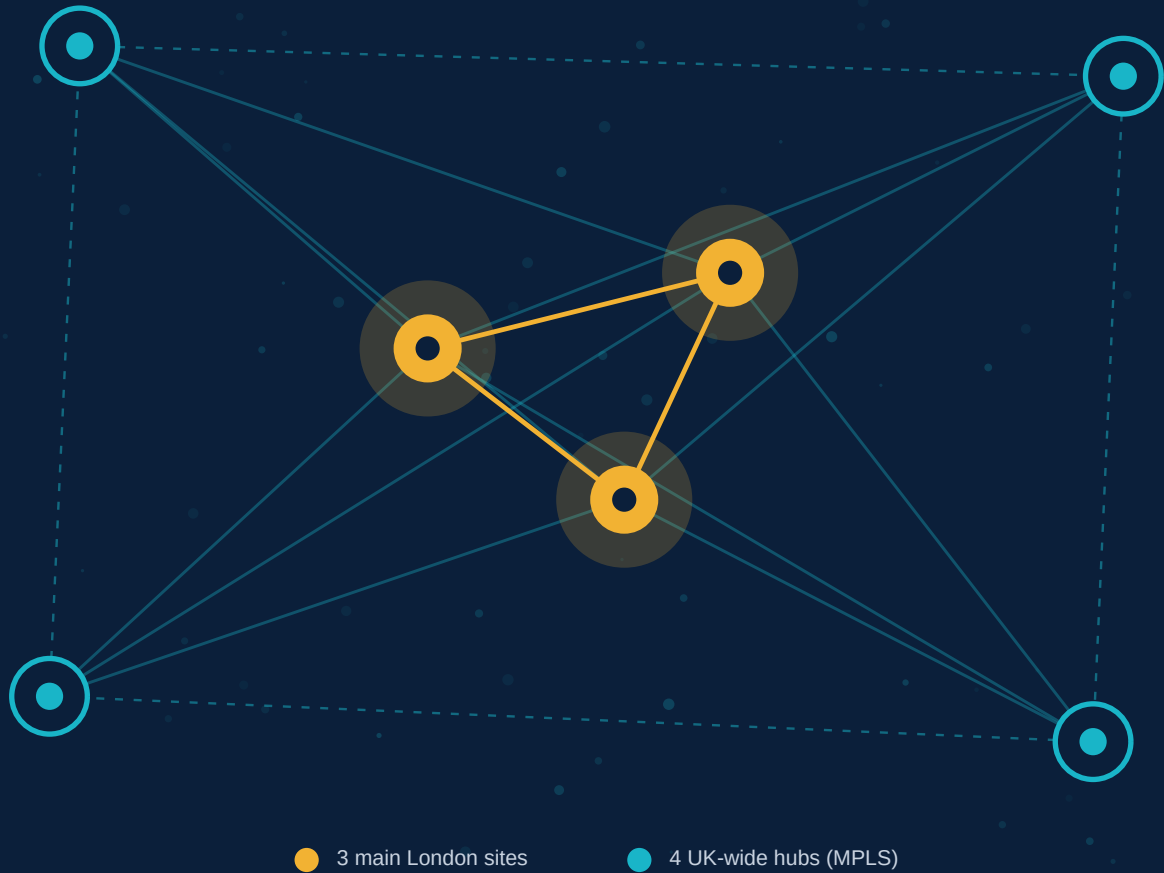




## PROJECT MANAGEMENT CASE STUDY

# Building and Retiring the London 2012 IT Infrastructure

Delivering an evergreen, short-term infrastructure on an immovable deadline, then decommissioning it cleanly

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**Computacenter**

Role: Project Manager

## Overview

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At Computacenter, I was Project Manager for delivering a complete, purpose-built IT infrastructure to support the London Olympics, and for decommissioning it once the Games ended. I led around 40 engineers across networking, messaging, and Wintel, alongside third-party contractors. The infrastructure had to go live on a date that could not move, run flawlessly for the Games, and then be safely retired, including the return of all leased hardware and the termination of carrier services.

## Scope

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- **Core server estate:** Exchange, SQL and other databases, WSUS, and gold-build server images
- **Identity and directory:** Domain controllers and domain services, Active Directory, Group Policy, LDAP
- **Network and security:** Cisco switching, fibre connectivity, MPLS wide-area network, VPN, firewall servers and policies, SSL, DNS
- **Application and access services:** App-V, RDP
- **Communications:** VoIP telephony and Office Communicator
- **Hardware leasing:** Short-term lease of servers and printers, including procurement, delivery, tracking, and return
- **Footprint:** 3 main London sites and 4 UK-wide hubs

## The Challenge

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- **An immovable deadline.** The opening ceremony fixed go-live, so everything was planned backwards from it.
- **High visibility.** Messaging, telephony, and network outages would have been immediate and public.
- **A built-in end date.** Every design choice had to allow for clean removal after the Games.
- **Long-lead connectivity.** MPLS circuits and fibre depend on carrier lead times outside our direct control, so they had to be ordered early and tracked closely.
- **Temporary hardware.** Servers and printers were leased for a fixed term, so delivery windows, lease periods, and return conditions had to be managed alongside the technical build.
- **Dead-on-arrival devices.** The biggest issue to overcome was that some delivered devices failed on arrival. With no room in the schedule for replacement lead times, this had to be solved through planning rather than reaction.
- **Coordination at scale.** Engineers from several disciplines and multiple contractors had to work as one team.

## Approach

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**Planning backwards.** I built the master schedule from the opening date, with milestones for design freeze, build, integration testing, and operational readiness. Cross-team dependencies, such as network and AD/DNS before Exchange and telephony, were tracked closely.

**Securing connectivity early.** The MPLS network linked the London sites and UK hubs into a single private WAN carrying data, voice, and messaging traffic. Because carrier provisioning had the longest lead times, circuit orders and fibre installations were placed at the start of the programme and managed as

critical-path items. Contract terms were aligned to the Games period so we were not tied to services beyond their useful life.

**Leasing as a delivery strategy.** Because the infrastructure had a defined lifespan, leasing servers and printers avoided owning hardware with no long-term use. I aligned lease terms and delivery dates with the build schedule, so hardware arrived when engineers needed it without paying for idle time. Every leased asset was recorded in the CMDB from delivery, with serial numbers, location, and return date.

**Mitigating dead-on-arrival risk.** When some devices arrived faulty, we relied on a surplus of gold stock held in reserve. Engineers could swap out failed units immediately, so no build milestone was affected. Holding spares was a small, deliberate cost that protected the schedule.

**Standardisation through gold builds.** Server gold builds and consistent Group Policy meant infrastructure could be deployed quickly and repeatably, with far fewer configuration errors. Standard hardware specifications also made swap-outs, lease sourcing, and later returns simpler.

**One team across disciplines.** I brought networking, messaging, and Wintel engineers under a single delivery cadence, with regular checkpoints, clear ownership of each workstream, and fast escalation of risks and blockers. Contractors, carriers, and leasing suppliers were managed through the same governance as the core team.

**Security and resilience.** Firewall policies, VPN access, and SSL were reviewed and tested before go-live, and redundancy was built into critical services such as directory, DNS, messaging, and WAN connectivity. Failover was tested rather than assumed.

**Integration testing and handover.** End-to-end testing validated that identity, network, messaging, and voice worked together over the MPLS and LAN before operations took ownership.

## Decommissioning

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After the Games, the focus moved to a controlled shutdown:

- Phased removal of servers, network equipment, printers, and telephony in a planned sequence
- Coordinated termination of MPLS circuits and fibre services with carriers, timed so connectivity stayed available until the last site was decommissioned
- Secure data destruction: all disk drives were wiped with Blancco and then physically shredded
- Clean removal of AD, DNS, and LDAP entries, and revocation of certificates, VPN access, and firewall rules so no access was left open
- Return of all leased kit and hardware to the lessor, with condition checks in place
- Full reconciliation of CMDB records against the physical assets returned
- Formal closure with contractors, carriers, and suppliers, and a lessons-learned review

## Results

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- Delivered the full infrastructure **on time and within budget**
- Supported 3 main London sites and 4 UK-wide hubs with **100% uptime**
- **No critical incidents outstanding at go-live**, with only 2 medium incidents
- **All leased kit and hardware returned with no lease termination charges**, and all CMDB records reconciled
- All data-bearing drives securely wiped and shredded
- Decommissioning and carrier circuit terminations completed cleanly

## Key Lessons

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- 1 **Plan the ending at the start.** Designing for removal reduced risk and cost at closure.
- 2 **Order long-lead items first.** Carrier circuits set the pace of the network build, so early ordering protected the schedule.
- 3 **Plan for hardware failure.** Surplus gold stock turned dead-on-arrival devices into a minor inconvenience instead of a schedule threat.
- 4 **Match commitments to the lifespan.** Leasing hardware and short-term carrier contracts kept costs proportionate to a temporary need, but only because end dates and conditions were tracked from day one.
- 5 **Standardise to go faster.** Gold builds and consistent policies made both deployment and teardown repeatable.
- 6 **Dependencies decide the schedule.** Network, directory, and DNS had to be right before everything built on them.
- 7 **Unified governance** across teams, contractors, carriers, and suppliers kept delivery on one plan.

## Reflection

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This project showed me that high-stakes delivery comes down to disciplined planning, clear ownership, and honest communication when the deadline cannot move.